Asian country that is expected to grow more rapidly than China itself, or for that matter any other major economy over the next few years, will be useful to China, even if Japan and the United States continue to oppose the BRI. China is keen that India should link its “Act East” policy to the BRI in the same way that India linked its “Act East” policy to the US rebalance to Asia, signalled through the Joint Statement during President Obama’s 2015 visit to India. Implementation of the BRI would be adversely affected without India’s participation. India will face difficult choices and will have to tread carefully, weighing each decision (such as on the BRI or on 5G technology) on its own merits.

It would be incorrect, however, to underestimate the significance of India’s gauntlet to China’s domination in Asia. It was observed almost two decades ago that the relationship between India and China is a case of “chronic conflict.”[53] The American scholar Wayne Wilcox famously stated in 1972 that with respect to China and Pakistan, India has to “hedge all bets and cover all contingencies.”[54] This situation has existed since 1958 and unfortunately, several decades later, still exists today. Given China’s strategic support for the nuclear and conventional arming of Pakistan, increasing Chinese military presence in the Indian Ocean and its littoral states, and the pressure of an unsettled border with China resulting in an adversarial relationship, India will naturally seek countervailing assurance. India will do this by deepening ties with the United States, Japan, Australia, South Korea, and ASEAN states, particularly Vietnam and Indonesia.

Nevertheless, India’s contestation and cooperation with China will go hand in hand. India has never contemplated a containment or alliance strategy directed against China. Indeed, India wishes for the opposite, to comprehensively engage China, much as the United States does. With India seeking sustained high growth and China transforming its economy to avoid the middle-income trap, both India and